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Léa

November 1942

Léa avoided looking at the red and black banner with the swastika above the door of the mairie in Combleux. As she climbed the stairs, the basket of food in her hand, her heart pounded with uncertainty. From Virginie's visits, she knew the mairie had a side annex where prisoners were held under provisional detention. Still, she'd need a convincing reason to be allowed to see Édouard.

Léa hadn't told anyone at home about the rifles Édouard had been storing for the Resistance. She didn't want to alarm Virginie, and the fewer people who knew, the better.

Inside the mairie, she crossed the herringbone parquet floor, passing men and women sitting on wooden benches set against a wall with an old tapestry. They seemed to be waiting, and she noticed a woman with a basket, surmising she was also here to deliver food. At the far end of the room, Léa strode up to where a man sat behind a wooden table.

"I'm here with food for Monsieur. Édouard LeBlanc."

"Over there," the man said, signaling to the benches she'd seen earlier. "Wait until you're called."

Léa sat down, crossed her ankles and placed the basket on her lap. Virginie had packed fresh clothes, an apple, cheese and a bottle of beer.

German officers stomped across the parquet, engaging in a heated exchange. On Léa's right was a conference room. The doors were closed, but she could hear men's voices coming from the other side. Maybe Édouard was held in there with the others. The Germans had arrested many men. Some were kept as hostages to pressure the guilty into confessing. Léa